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TENANTS' UNION TO COMBAT INDECENT HOUSING, POLICE TERROR



At a recent Oakland Housing Authority Commission hearing, BPP chairperson ELAINE BROWN (standing) and San Antonio Projects residents (left to right, in front row) BLANCHE MURPHY, DOROTHY BURTON, PATRICIA GOLSON, JACKIE WALTON and EARLINE MITCHELL demanded an end to the "armed camp" atmosphere in San Antonio that has been created by the OHA security guards and Oakland police.

(Oakland, Calif.) - By their own say so the residents of San Antonio Housing Projects here, like many public housing tenants throughout the country, are "angry, frustrated and just plain fed up" over the conditions of indecent housing and rampant police brutality in which they are forced to live.

But, unlike the situation in other areas, the people in San Antonio are organizing for immediate, positive change.

Last Monday evening, at a loud, vocal and freewheeling meeting held at the friendly confines of the nearby Oakland Community Learning Center (OCLC), dozens of San Antonio residents got together to form the San Antonio Tenants' Union in a united effort to solve their problems.

At the same time, nonresidents of the besieged 178-unit facility — led by Elaine Brown, chairperson of the Black Panther Party, and Rev. Michael Dunn, pastor of Elmhurst Presbyterian Church and president of East Oakland Clergy — formed the Citizens Concerned for San Antonio Projects as a firm support group for the Tenants' Union.

The immediate task before the Tenants' Union will be to organize others to attend a soon-to-be held meeting of the Oakland Housing Authority Commission (OHAC) to discuss the many complaints of area residents.

This meeting with OHAC, to be held in San Antonio "as soon as possible," results from a pledge made by OHC commissioners earlier in the day to set up such a meeting and to hear what the tenants had to say.

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